

“NO ONE CAN BE A LEADER UNLESS HE SETS A PERSONAL EXAMPLE.”

Born in Coorg (Kodagu), **KM Cariappa’s** life involved several firsts. He was one of the first Indians to be inducted as a King’s Commissioned Indian Officer, and the first Indian commander-in-chief of the army. He is credited with transforming the colonial army into a national army that was resolutely apolitical. He also did away with archaic British recruitment practices based on caste and regional biases, and established new units that recruited members from all castes and classes. Cariappa was known to be a stickler for rules, but also as an officer deeply invested in the well-being of his troops, ex-servicemen and their families. He continued to visit the troops to improve morale after he had retired, especially during the wars of 1965 and 1971.

In 1986, he was elevated to the rank of Field Marshal (the highest in the army). He was the second of only two army officers ever so honoured. The day Cariappa took over as Army Chief, 15 January, is now celebrated every year as Army Day.